People, Places and Things

By Duncan Macmillan

Suggested Roles: *ACTOR: Doctor, Therapist, Paul, Mark*
ACTRESS: Emma. Meredith, Laura

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

DOCTOR: **(Pg 24-27)** Nina? Nina? *(No response)* Excuse me, hello.

EMMA: *(jittery, nervous, obviously under the influence) Sorry*. Yes, that's me.

DOCTOR: Great. *(reviews the intake form)* Your name is 'Nina" and you're an alcoholic and drug addict.

EMMA: This was a mistake.

DOCTOR: You're not an alcoholic and drug addict?

EMMA: I'm not saying I'm anything. I just want to get clean, get my certificate and go back to work.

DOCTOR: Certificate?

EMMA: A piece of paper or a signed whatever, something that says I can work. That I'm not a risk.

DOCTOR: Once you complete the grogram we can . . .

EMMA: *(interrupting)* How long will that take?

DOCTOR: It varies. First, I'll need to see your results and take a history and psychological examination. *(consulting the form)* Benzodiazepine, Lorazepam.

EMMA: Valium, yeah. For anxiety. It's a prescription.

DOCTOR: Detoxing from benzos takes about ten days. You'll start tonight and tomorrow morning you can begin with Group.

EMMA: I don't need that; I just need the first thing.

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DOCTOR: Nina, the Group is the program. The truth is that it doesn't take long to get everything out of your body. It's the behavior that is the important thing to address. We can't do that until we've dealt with the physical symptoms. Then it's twenty-eight days of therapy. Ideally, it'll be closer to ninety.

EMMA: Ninety? No, that's not possible.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Recovery from an addiction is a journey between life and death that can only be walked one day at a time.*
ACTRESS: *Life has to win every single day.*
ACTOR: *And death only has to win once.*
TOGETHER: *People, Places and Things by Duncan Macmillan*

DOCTOR: Blackouts . . . Memory loss . . . It says here 'suicide attempt.'

EMMA: Not a successful one. That's me. Never seeing anything through. Violin lessons. Diets. Suicide attempts. I never finish what I start.

DOCTOR: Your addiction will fight any progress. It's a parasite and it will fight for its own survival until you're dead. But progress is possible. I just need to hear you say that you are willing and motivated to make changes.

EMMA: I know that the next time I drink or use that'll be it. I'll be dead. I'm not sure if I knew that until now, until I just literally just said it. But it's true. It's going to kill me. *(She rubs her eyes)* Yes. I need help. Please help me.

DOCTOR: **(Pg 39-40)** The program works for a lot of people. **(Pg 27)** Let's start with your name shall we? Your real name.

EMMA: Emma. *(cynical)* **(Pg 39)** If it's vital to my recovery that I come to believe in a power greater than me – to turn my will and my life over to God and have Him remove my defects of character – if all this depends on me having a spiritual awakening, then we might all just be wasting our time.

DOCTOR: You're worried about the steps.

EMMA: I'm worried that a trained medical professional can also wear a crucifix.

DOCTOR: I don't believe the scientific methods disproves the existence of . . .

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EMMA: *(bitterly interrupting)* Of course it does. I really need you to be cleverer than this. Otherwise, I'm going to leave. I'm not powerless. I'm not helpless. I don't believe addiction is a disease and I'm scared and angered by the suggestion that from now on it's either eternal abstinence or binge to death. I can't surrender to a higher power because there isn't one. There just isn't. My brother had a brain hemorrhage while reading Pinocchio to a group of five-year-olds. Mark. Hew was two years younger than me and never touched drugs or alcohol. He ran marathons. For charity. I should have died a thousand times, but it was him.

DOCTOR: When did you start using, Emma? **(Pg 37)** Before you join the Group I need some historical context for your using.

EMMA: **(Pg 40-42)** If I tell you I was sexually abused or the child of alcoholics, if I tell you I returned from back-to-back tours of Iraq and started to self-medicate; is that the kind of thing you want to hear?

DOCTOR: Is it the truth?

EMMA: No. I never had a brother. And he didn't die in front of children. He died in his car. Or he was stillborn maybe. Or he grew up and died of old age.

DOCTOR: Do you lie to protect yourself or your addiction?

EMMA: I can't base my survival on slogans and abstractions and vagueness. I'm not someone who can do Pilates on a beach and mistake relaxation for spirituality. I spent a year in the Far East, but I didn't find enlightenment, I found slums and sex tourism. I need something definitive. I need to be fixed.

DOCTOR: It doesn't work like that. It's a long-term, daily . . .

EMMA: I don't do long-term.

DOCTOR: You're going to learn. The strategies you've been using just aren't working. Intellectually inferior as I may be, I'm trying to save your life. Now, sit down. *(Emma sits)* The Twelve Steps outline the process of recovery. Have you heard the expression "powerless over nouns'?

EMMA: Nouns? As in

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DOCTOR: People, places and things. It's a rewrite of Step One of Twelve. Instead of declaring ourselves powerless over alcohol or drugs, we admit that we are powerless over people, places and things. People who make us want to relapse, places we associate with using and things that reactivate old behavior. When you're in recovery

EMMA: Back in the real world.

DOCTOR: You'll need to find a way to handle being in those places, with those people.

EMMA: And those things. I find reality pretty difficult. I find picking up my phone to be a mammoth struggle. The friends who won't see me anymore. The bombings and beheadings, the moral ambivalence you have to have to just be able to carry on with your day. Drugs and alcohol have never let me down. There are substances I can put into my bloodstream that make the world perfect.

DOCTOR: I can't force you to stay. I can't force you to be truthful. I can tell you that the process only works if you are honest. With yourself, with me and with others. Denial is what kills you. (beat) You've already come so far Emma. Don't let that be for nothing. I'd like you to meet the Group.

******** GROUP THERAPY*******

THERAPIST: (Pg 43) Hi. I'm Lydia, one of the therapists here. Why don't you introduce yourself?

EMMA: Er, okay. Hello everyone I'm . . . Emma.

MEREDITH: (Pg 54) I'm Meredith and I'm a Heroin addict.

TOGETHER AS GROUP: Hello, Meredith.

LAURA: Hello, I'm Laura. I'm an alcoholic.

TOGETHER AS GROUP: Hello, Laura.

THERAPIST: (Pg 43-44) Emma, why don't you tell us about yourself?

EMMA: Seriously? I have to just jump straight in? **(Pg 45-47)** *(Suddenly the door opens and Paul enters, urgently)*

PAUL: I'd like to say something to the Group please.

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THERAPIST: Mr. Waverly, I'm sorry but your treatment has been terminated. You can't be in here.

PAUL: *(takes a piece of paper from his pocket and reads)* I want to apologize to you all with my whole heart. I know that my behavior here was stupid and dangerous. I smuggled in some substances. Ketamine. *(he lowers the paper – this is hard for him)* But I don't' like begging. I was making progress here. I was doing well. Please. Please give me a second chance. I wouldn't have used if what happened hadn't happened.

EMMA: What happened?

PAUL: Robert. My fiancé. My partner of eighteen years. Dead. Heroin. I can't go home again. It's not real. I don't want to die. I want it all to stop.

EMMA: **(Pg 48)** I'm sorry your fiancé died. My brother died too. The week before I came here. Pills. I found him in the stairwell of our building curled into a ball. He cried blood. I wish I'd died instead. I wish I'd died without having to see him dead. We're the same.

THERAPIST: Paul, you understand you can't simply re-join the Group.

PAUL: *(looks around, laughs bitterly)* None of this is real. When you're sitting here tonight being all serious, think of me out there. I'll be having the night of my life. *(Paul leaves, beat)*

THERAPIST: **(Pg 55)** Would you like to speak to the Group Emma?

EMMA: No.

MARK: *(steps up to fill the silence)* **(Pg 54)** [Hello, I'm Mark] I'm a drug addict. **(Pg 58)** Amends. That's the hardest part of this whole thing. I can't forgive myself for a lot of things, so I can't expect other to. My eldest sister, she was pouring a bottle of Smirnoff down the sink. Vodka to me was like spinach to Popeye. I didn't know my own strength. I broke her jaw then stamped on her leg, broke her ankle. She forgave me. *(he is finding his hard; beat)* My gran. She raised me. Cancer. She was in pain and I *(big breath in an out, trying to keep his composure)* I took her pain relief. I'd hear her calling out. Screaming. And I'd be like 'sorry Nan. There's nothing left.' Now she's dead so how do I amend for that?

EMMA: **(Pg 60-61)** *(softly)* Hello. I'm Emma. I'm an alcoholic and drug addict.

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MARK: I've seen you onstage a few time. I remember thinking, she's going to be great.

EMMA: I used to think that too. With a play you get instructions. Stage directions. Dialogue. Someone tells you where to be and when. You get to live the most intense moments of a life over and over again. You get to practice. For weeks. And you're applauded. Then you leave through stage door. Back to real life. Audition comes in. Never hear back. You try not to take it personally. But you keep going because sometimes, if you're really lucky, you get to be onstage and say things that are absolutely true, even if they're mad-up. You get to do things which feel more real to you, more authentic, more meaningful than anything in your own life. You get to speak poetry . . . *(From Antigone)* ***When he shall die, take him and cut him out in little stars, and he will make the face of heaven so fine that all the world will be in love with night, and pay no worship to the garish sun.*** I played Antigone and every night my heart broke about her dead brother. Then my own brother died and I didn't feel anything. I'm not avoiding talking to the Group because I've got something to hide. It's the opposite. If I'm not in character, I'm not sure I'm really there. **(Pg 63)** I'm brilliant at being other people and totally useless at being myself. **(Pg 61)** I'm nothing. *(long beat)*

(Pg 64) *(with growing anger)* I'd like to believe that my problems are meaningful. But they're not. There are people dying of thirst. People living in war zones and here we are thinking about ourselves. As if we can solve everything by confronting our own defects. We're not defective. It's the world that's f****ed. *(She steps out of the scene and speaks to the audience)*

(Pg 60) *(softly)* Hello. I'm Emma. I'm an alcoholic and drug addict. **(Pg 87)** *(sadly)* In rehab they tell you: avoid people who make you want to relapse. Places you associate with using and objects that might be a trigger. People, places and things. That's basically, you know. . . everything.

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AWARD HISTORY

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